

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 155

Culture (OWC): [Ovambo \(FX08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1898-1907

Coverage Date: 1898 AD - 1907 AD

Place Coverage

north-central Namibia; south-central Angola

Section Title(S): 6. Greeting Of Guests

Some of the people's customs would appear to us to be absolutely tactless at first glance. I can remember an invitation which I and my wife once received from a noble lady and which we gladly accepted. After we had been received and greeted in a most friendly manner, a large beer pot was brought in. Our hostess took it upon herself to pour the beer, and I was astounded to observe that she drank the first cup she had filled, and only then gave something to drink to her guests. What might be the reason? She merely wanted to show us that we, too, could drink the beer offered to us without being concerned, i.e. without having to be afraid that we might be poisoned. As I was later able to observe, this custom is strictly followed by many. All they intend doing is to show the guest that the beverage does not contain anything that might be detrimental to his health. In their relations with one another, this custom is taken so far that the host first takes a sip from the cup he intends offering to his guest, fills it again and then passes it to the person concerned.

[123
Observation In
Research](#)
[186
Cultural Identity And
Pride](#)
[574
Visiting And Hospitality](#)
[576
Etiquette](#)

The inhabitants of Ovamboland prefer to maintain a pleasant, happy atmosphere during their conversations. Especially after the evening meal, they love to sit at the fire until late at night. On such occasions, each one attempts to the best of his abilities to bring about a lively conversation, be it by telling all kinds of jokes and anecdotes one happens to think of, or by entertaining the others with an interesting tale or account.

[461
Labor And Leisure](#)
[521
Conversation](#)
[522
Humor](#)
[576
Etiquette](#)

People with a truly firm character who know exactly what they want and are not easily detracted by anything or anybody, are rare. Most are concerned primarily with their personal gain and will act accordingly on every occasion, be it by just or unjust means. In a country in which the most brutal injustices are the order of the day, the position of the missionary can, at times, also be an extremely difficult one. How should he, for example, behave towards the king if the king practises the most brutal, violent acts and his noblemen attempt to emulate him? Is he to remain silent, thinking that the king is the lord of the land and may do as he pleases? If he did, he would surely be but a poor messenger of peace. He must reproach and take action against such deeds even if they are performed by the highest institutions; the most difficult issue here being the matter of how to do it. In their youthful enthusiasm, many have already made mistakes here. A person can take action in this regard only once he has been in the country for a longer period of time and is trusted ¹⁵⁶ by the king and some of his subjects. Without giving any further advice in this regard, I will restrict myself to providing an account of some of the experiences I made with the king and a few other high-ranking personalities.

123
Observation In
Research

156
Social Personality

521
Conversation

522
Humor

576
Etiquette

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)